VLTHR LAB

Applied business and operational research | Operational perspective + Strategic/business perspective

RESEARCH PLAN

A Comparative Analysis of How In-House and Outsourced Operations Affect a Company's Risk Profile

Purpose. Establish a controlled research process from Ground 0 through evidence acquisition, analysis, development, validation and final reporting.

1. RESEARCH OBJECTIVE

Core question: How does the choice between in-house and outsourced operations affect a company's risk profile from operational and strategic/business perspectives?

Supporting focus: identify risks retained, transferred, introduced or amplified; examine control, reliability, response, continuity, capability, dependency, flexibility and strategic exposure; identify conditions that change outcomes; develop a usable comparative risk framework.

2. RESEARCH POSITIONING

Position the work as an applied investigation of a practical business problem while remaining transparent about the academic context.

> ***External positioning:*** *"An applied research study examining how companies manage operational and strategic risk when activities are performed internally versus through external providers."*

The student/university identity remains visible for legitimacy. The business problem, professional relevance, low information burden, data protection and contribution of industry evidence should be the primary reasons for participation.

3. DATA ACQUISITION TARGETS

METRIC	MINIMUM	PREFERRED
Qualified company/professional contacts	250	300-500
Usable questionnaire responses	25	30-40
Planned response rate	10%	>10% where achievable

Important: 25 responses are an exploratory minimum, not an automatic basis for broad statistical generalisation. The study therefore combines survey evidence with literature, cases, secondary company evidence and professional evidence.

4. WHO TO TARGET

Operations General Management Procurement Supply Chain Maintenance Engineering HSE Risk Finance IT/Technology. Quality Business Continuity Asset Management Contract/Vendor Management.

Seek variation across in-house, outsourced, hybrid and multi-sourced operating models, with diversity across industries and company sizes where feasible.

5. REDUCING THE "STUDENT SEEKING DATA" BARRIER

LAYER	POSITIONING ACTION
Legitimacy	Identify researcher, programme/institution, title, supervisor where appropriate and contact.
Business relevance	Lead with the operational/strategic risk problem, not the thesis requirement.
Professional relevance	Target people whose roles give them direct operating-model knowledge.
Low burden	State completion time; do not request confidential information; explain data handling.
Value exchange	Offer an aggregated findings/risk-framework summary after completion without promising a result.

6. CONTACT DATA TO CAPTURE

Company Industry Region Size Contact Job title Function Email Operating-model relevance Source/provenance. Contact date • Response status Follow-up status.

7. RESEARCH EVIDENCE STREAMS

Literature: peer-reviewed research, books, theses, industry research, standards and frameworks. Primary: questionnaire, interviews and professional responses. Secondary: company reports, operational disclosures, supplier/procurement information and incidents where available. Cases: documented insourcing, outsourcing, hybrid operation, supplier failure, disruption, transition and recovery.

RESEARCH ROADMAP & VALIDATION GATES

Each phase produces an output and must pass its gate before unresolved structural issues are allowed to propagate into the next phase.

PHASE	WORK	PRIMARY OUTPUT	GATE
0	Research Activation	Ground-0 baseline, repository, registers, permissions	G0
1	Problem Definition	Validated problem, scope, terminology	G1
2	Research Architecture	Questions, variables, methods, evidence map	G2
3	Knowledge Base	Literature/theory/gap framework	G3

PHASE	WORK	PRIMARY OUTPUT	GATE
4	Risk & Measurement	Risk taxonomy + measurement framework	G4
5	Data Acquisition	Acquisition plan + contact system	G5
6	Instrument Development	Questionnaire/interview tools + pilot	G6
7	Data Collection	Primary + secondary dataset	G7
8	Data QA/QC	Validated dataset/evidence	G8
9	Analysis & Modelling	Comparative findings/model	G9
10	Development	Research framework/artefact	G10
11	Validation & Synthesis	Validated conclusions	G11
12	Final Reporting	Final thesis/report	G12

8. CORE RESEARCH LOGIC

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Operating model → Resource configuration → Control distribution → Dependency structure → Risk exposure → Risk event → Consequence → Response/recovery → Residual risk.
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Operational risk: process control, quality, reliability, downtime, capacity, labour/skills, maintenance, information flow, response time, flexibility, continuity, supplier performance, technology dependency, safety and compliance.

Strategic/business risk: cost exposure, capital and transaction costs, strategic dependency, vendor lock-in, core competence, scalability, bargaining power, knowledge retention, IP, continuity, reputation and financial exposure.

9. THEORETICAL / KNOWLEDGE BASE

Investigate Transaction Cost Economics, Resource-Based View, Resource Dependence Theory, Agency Theory, Dynamic Capabilities, governance/relational theories and operational resilience. Retain only theories that materially explain the research problem.

Every important claim should preserve source, date, context, population/sample, method, variable, finding, limitation, applicability and contradictory evidence.

10. RISK & MEASUREMENT MODEL

Assess risk through exposure, probability, impact, detectability, controllability, transferability, recoverability and persistence.

Distinguish risk retained, transferred, introduced, reduced, amplified and shared.

11. QUESTIONNAIRE DEVELOPMENT

Instrument sections: respondent context; company context; operating model; activity characteristics; operational risk; strategic/business risk; dependency; control; capability; continuity/resilience; outsourcing/insourcing experience; outcomes; optional qualitative observations.

Pilot before mass distribution. Test comprehension, completion time, ambiguity, data structure and analysis compatibility. No mass campaign before G6.

12. DATA COLLECTION CAMPAIGN

Wave 1: initial distribution. Wave 2: follow-up. Wave 3: final targeted follow-up. Wave 4: supplementary acquisition if required. Literature, case and secondary evidence collection runs in parallel.

Target 250+ qualified contacts, minimum 25 usable responses, preferred 30-40. Track contact provenance, response rate, completion rate and exclusions.

DEVELOPMENT, VALIDATION & DELIVERY

The final research product should convert evidence into a defensible comparative framework rather than stopping at descriptive survey results.

13. DATA QA/QC

Screen for completeness, duplication, contradictions, implausible answers, respondent relevance, missing data and insufficient engagement. Classify responses as accepted, conditionally usable or excluded, with reasons recorded.

Evidence should distinguish directly observed evidence, respondent-reported evidence, documented company evidence, academic evidence, industry evidence, inference and unresolved uncertainty.

14. DEVELOPMENT STRATEGY

Operating Model Risk Assessment Framework

- **Inputs:** activity, criticality, operating model, resources, supplier structure, capability requirements, dependencies and controls.
- **Logic:** Operating Model → Dependency → Risk Mechanism → Exposure → Consequence → Response → Residual Risk.
- **Outputs:** operational risk profile, strategic/business risk profile, risk transfer map, dependency map, control map and uncertainty assessment.

The development artefact is selected and finalised after the problem, evidence and research questions have been validated, rather than being assumed at the start.

15. RESEARCH DATA / EVIDENCE ARCHITECTURE

OPERATING / EXPERIENCE GRAPH	EVIDENCE GRAPH
Company → Activity → Operating Model → Resource → Dependency → Control → Risk → Event → Consequence → Response → Outcome	Source → Evidence → Claim → Finding → Relationship → Validation

16. QUALITY & UNCERTAINTY CONTROLS

CONTROL	FUNCTION
DQS	Data completeness, consistency, validity, duplication and provenance.
DREV	Evidence quality, relevance, methodological strength, applicability and contradictions.
UNPF	Known / probable / uncertain / unknown / unsupported classification.
CRDS	Claim → risk mechanism → evidence → operational consequence → business consequence → validation.
PURF	Progress certainty from reality/context through uncertainty, decomposition, state estimation, risk inference and validation.

17. VALIDATION STRATEGY

Literature validation: compare model with established research. Data validation: test relationships against primary responses. Case validation: compare with documented cases. Model validation: test logical consistency. Sensitivity: test changes in supplier reliability, criticality, dependency, capability and recovery time. Contradiction analysis: actively seek evidence that challenges emerging conclusions.

18. INDICATIVE TIMELINE

PERIOD	MAIN ACTIVITY
Weeks 0–1	Ground 0 + Problem, architecture, knowledge base, risk framework setup
Week 2	Questionnaire pilot + acquisition readiness
Week 3	Targeted contact campaign & data acquisition completed
Weeks 4–6	QA/QC, comparative analysis, framework/model development, validation & final thesis/report reporting

19. FINAL SUCCESS CRITERIA

250+ qualified contacts • 25 minimum usable responses • 30–40 preferred • multi-source evidence • validated dataset • evidence-backed comparative findings • defensible risk framework • validated research artefact • final thesis/report with explicit limitations and uncertainty.

FINAL POSITIONING

> *"WE are conducting an applied research study into how organisations structure operational activities and how those choices affect operational and strategic risk. WE are collecting evidence from professionals with direct experience in in-house, outsourced, hybrid or multi-sourced operations."*

Academic status remains transparent. The engagement is positioned around a real business problem, professional expertise and structured evidence contribution, without asking respondents to disclose confidential company information.